Taiwan’s Elections and Democratization

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Why Taiwan's Elections Matter

- Taiwan is one of the most vibrant democracies in East Asia.
- According to Huntington's theory, Taiwan is the third-wave democracy with two party turnover
- Elections ensure accountability and reflect identity politics.
- Election plays an important role in Taiwan's democratization.
- Does election system or political culture shape voting behavior and party system?
- Under external threat, will election help consolidate Taiwan democracy or shatter it?

Historical Roots

- Elections existed during Japanese colonial rule and early KMT rule but mainly at local levels.
- During Japanese colonization (1895–1945), Taiwan held its first local counselor elections in 1935, allowing male residents over 25 to vote for half of local assembly members in 9 cities.
- The number of eligible Japanese and Taiwanese voters are 26,479 and 24,578, respectively.
- The elections were held again in 1939, but the 1943 election was canceled due to the Second World War.

Election History

- **1935 – First local elections under Japanese rule**
  Municipal and prefectural councils introduced; however, **suffrage limited to male taxpayers**, and many members were still appointed.
- **1947 – First national elections in the Republic of China**
  Representatives elected to the **Legislative Yuan and National Assembly** before the KMT retreated to Taiwan.
- **1949–1987 – Martial law period**
  National representatives elected in **1947 kept their seats indefinitely**, creating the so-called **"Ten-Thousand-Year Parliament."**
- **1950 – Regular local elections introduced in Taiwan**
  Elections held for **county magistrates, mayors, township chiefs, and local councils**.
- **Opposition participation through local elections**
  Non-KMT candidates (later called the **Tangwai movement**) began winning local offices in the **1960s–1980s**.
- **By the 1980s:** Taiwan had **decades of electoral experience at the local level**, which helped facilitate **democratic transition after martial law ended in 1987**.

Elections and Democratization

- Local elections served as a safety valve allowing limited opposition competition.
- Once elected, the opposition activists challenged the KMT's authoritarian regime.
- In 1951, Kuo Yu-shin (郭雨新) was elected as the first non-KMT Provincial Assembly Member.
- In 1960, Yu Den-fa (余登發), was elected as the Kaohsiung County mayor. He was suspended and arrested later.

Chung-li Incident (1977)

Ciaotao Rally (1979)

Formosa Incident (1979)

DPP founded (1986)

Turning Points

- 1992 Legislative Yuan reelection
- Taiwan held the first full reelection of the Legislative Yuan, replacing mainland-elected representatives and defining the status quo of a democratic Taiwan, distinct from the PRC.
- 1996 first direct presidential election:
- It symbolizes democratic sovereignty and presidential system.
- 2000 peaceful power transition
- The victory of Chen Shui-bian (DPP) ended decades of Kuomintang rule and marked Taiwan's first peaceful transfer of power between parties.

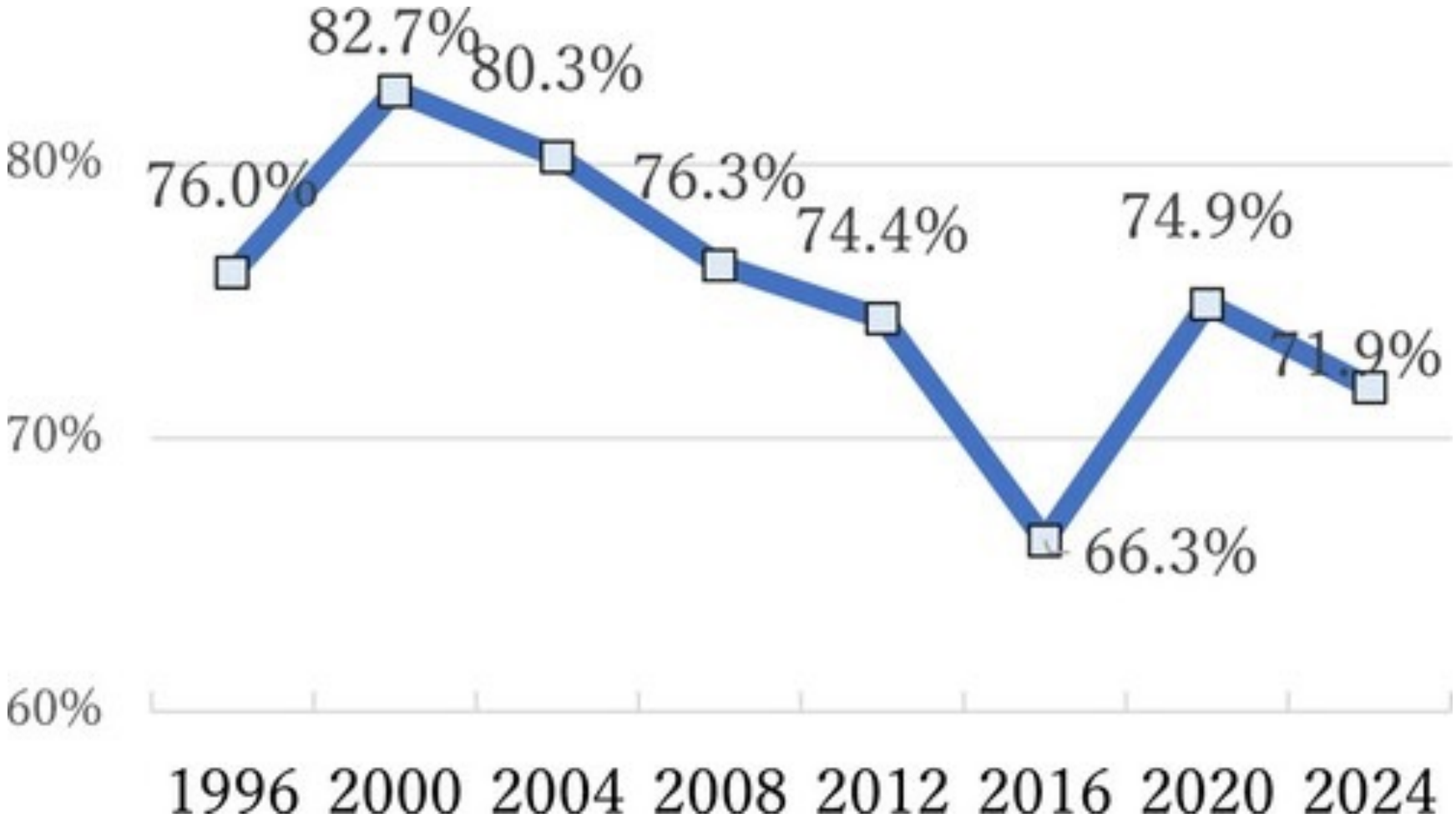
Election Issues

- After DPP was established, democratization issue (reform vs. social order) was replaced by national identity (independence vs. unification).
- The DPP promoted the idea of self-determination, claiming to represent the indigenous Taiwanese.
- The KMT insisted on continuation of Republic of China, calling the DPP the separationists.
- Environmental protection, labor, anti-nuclear power, woman rights, and unemployment issues were not prioritized.

Electoral Participation

- Since Taiwan is young democracy, Taiwanese people are interested in politics.
- Due to the high competitiveness, the turnout rates in the presidential election are around 70 percent. The lowest one occurred in 2016.
- The turnout rates in the county/city mayoral elections are around 60 percent.
- Because there is no absentee vote, many of young voters have to travel back to their hometown to vote.
- Voting Day is scheduled on Saturday, but many people still work.

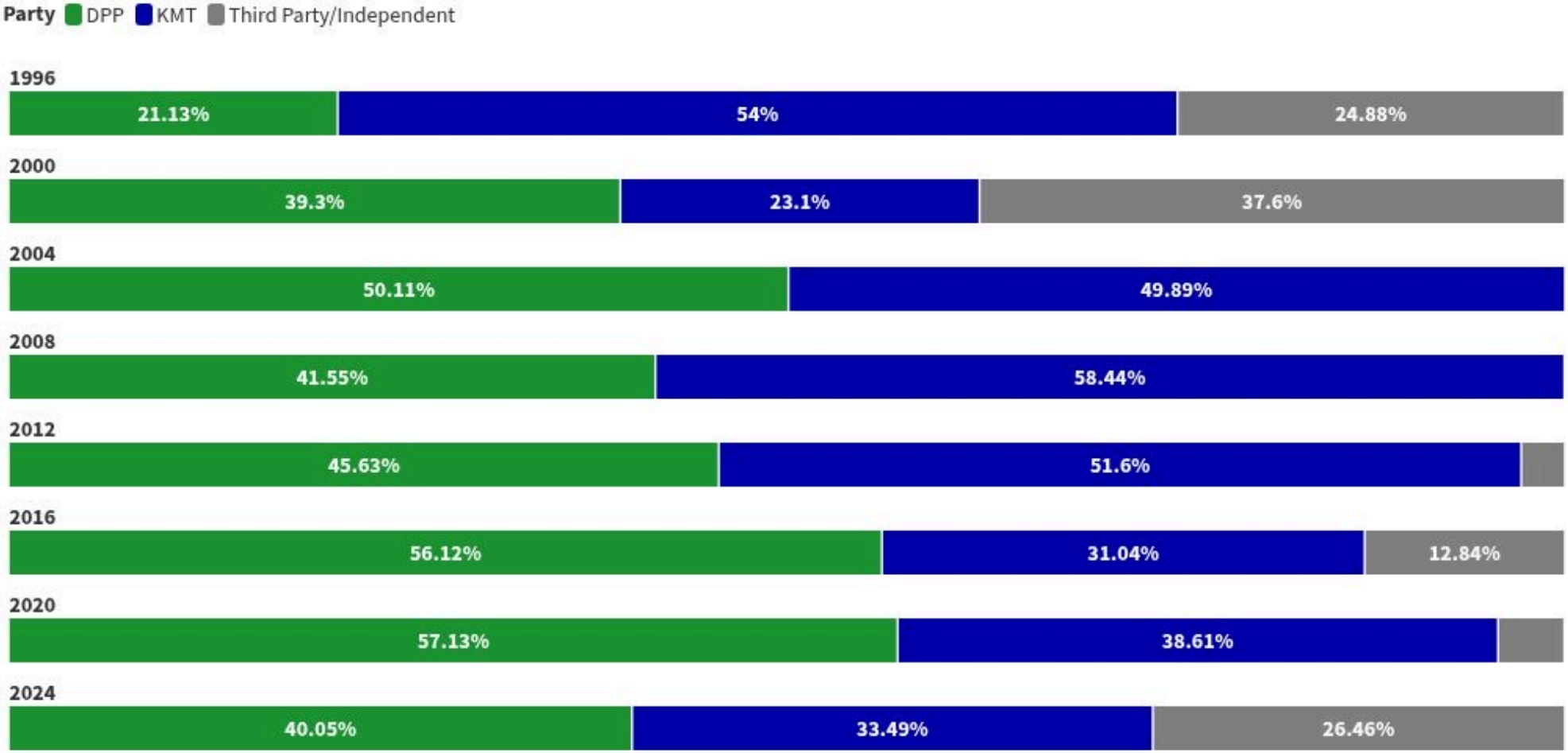
Turnout Rates in Presidential Elections



Party System

- After a series of legislative and local elections, the DPP became the major party. The presidential system fosters Taiwan's two-party system.
- Some third parties like New Party, People's First Party (PFP, James Soong) and New Power Party (NPP, Kuo-chang Huang) emerged, they cannot compete against DPP or KMT in the presidential election.
- Taiwan People's Party (TPP, Ko Wen-je) was founded in 2020. Ko almost won the second place in the 2024 presidential election.
- People may sincerely vote, but the two major parties have much more resources.

1996–2024 Taiwanese Presidential Election Results



Sources: Central Election Commission (CEC, 中央選舉委員會), CSIS • By Tracy Weener

Party Machines

- Campaign mobilization through organization, data, and grassroots networks.

Local Factions

- Local elites mobilize voters through long-term reciprocity networks.

How People Vote

- Urban ideological voting vs rural network voting.

Party Identification

- Pan-Blue vs Pan-Green divide and rise of the Third Force.

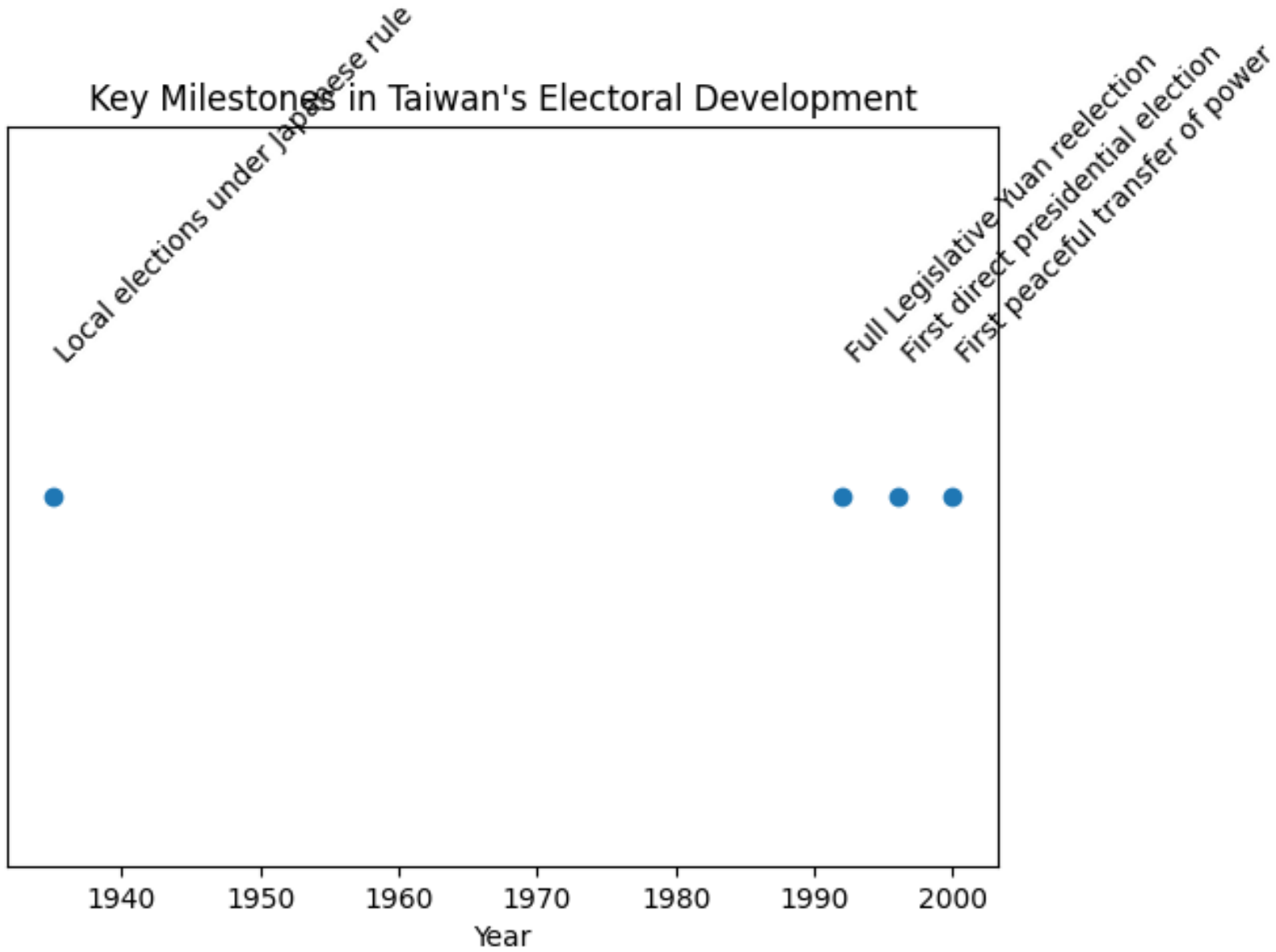
Candidate Selection

- Primaries using polls and party member votes; parachute vs local candidates.

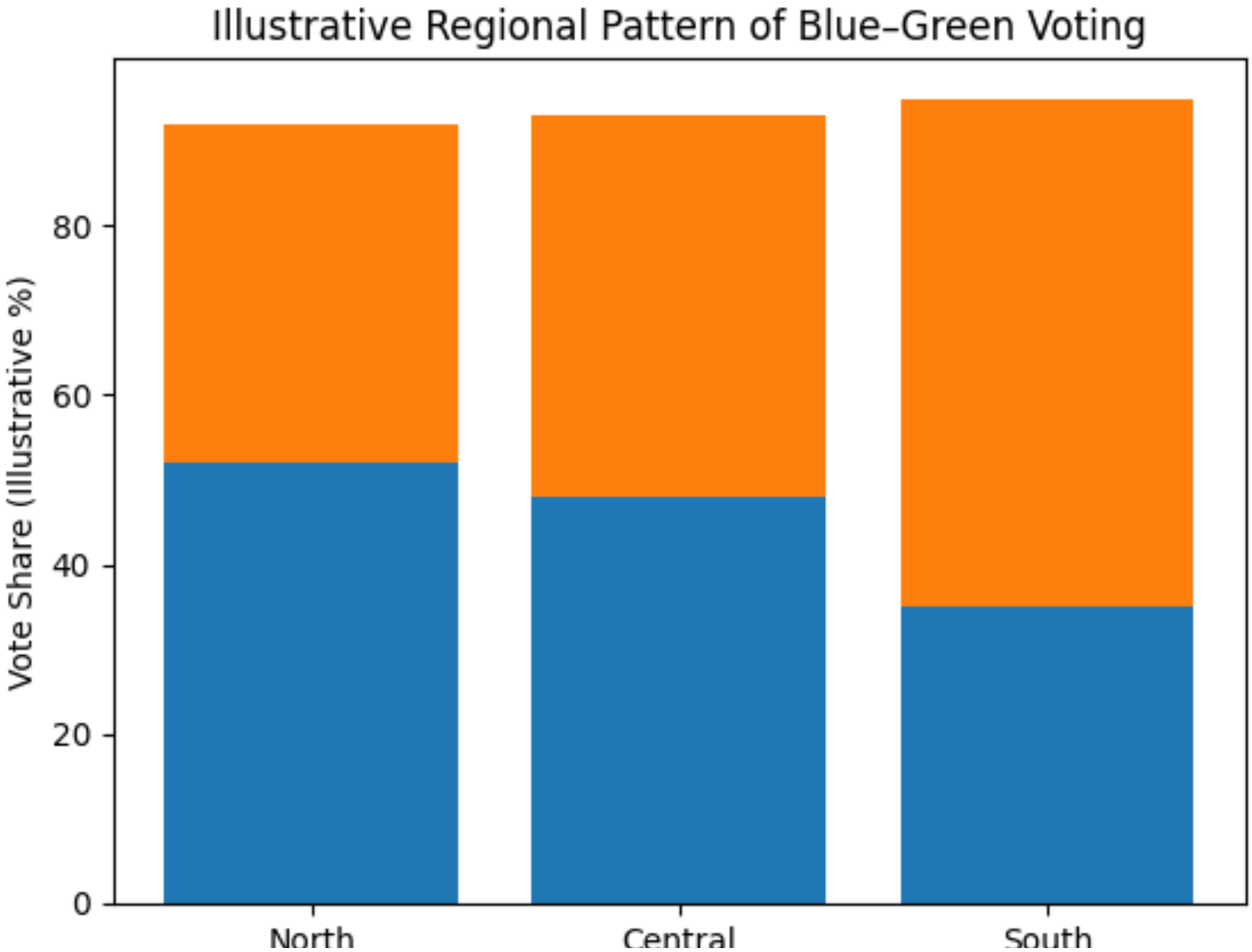
Conclusion

- Taiwan elections combine modern democratic institutions with deep political culture.

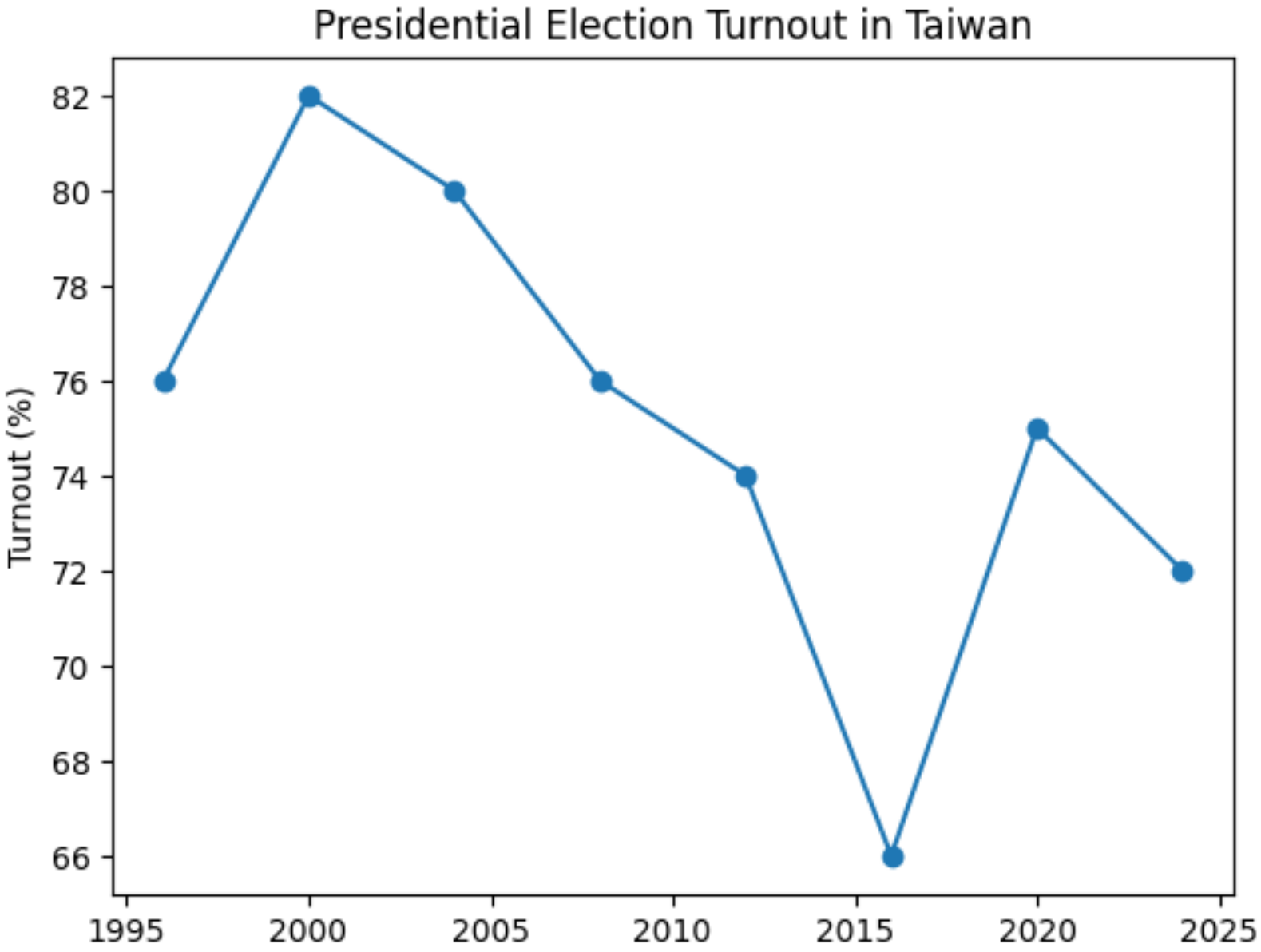
Taiwan Election Timeline



Blue–Green Regional Voting Pattern



Presidential Election Turnout



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